

The Repair Economy: A Local Handbook for Extending the Life of Things

Book overview

Author: Bela Nikitina, PhD

The Repair Economy is a practice-oriented book about making repair, reuse and longer product lifetimes part of local economic development and municipal policy. It is conceived as a companion to *Municipal Waste Management in Israel: A Civic Handbook*, but shifts the focus from managing waste after it has been generated to preventing objects from becoming waste in the first place.

The book asks how a territory can build a durable system in which repair keeps objects in use, sustains local jobs and skills, and remains economically accessible to residents. It argues that responsible-consumption campaigns, isolated repair workshops and technological solutions cannot achieve this alone. A repair economy begins to operate at meaningful scale when three lines are aligned within a territory: legislation and regulation; physical and organisational infrastructure; and economic incentives supporting a viable market for repair.

The book brings together the sociology of repair and maintenance, public-policy analysis and local economic development. It follows the path of an object from breakdown to repair, reuse or disposal; maps formal, semi-formal and informal repair activity; and examines invisible labour, the transmission of practical skills, and the gender and migration dimensions of repair work. Particular attention is given to the structural tension between producers that may benefit from shorter product lifetimes and territories that benefit from employment, resource conservation and keeping expenditure within the local economy.

Comparative cases from Austria, France, Germany, Sweden and Scotland demonstrate different routes towards repair and reuse systems. They include repair subsidies, extended producer responsibility, municipal reuse centres, social enterprises, vocational training and public procurement of reused goods. The central lesson is not that one model should be copied everywhere, but that sequencing matters: financial incentives cannot succeed without adequate repair capacity, while local workshops remain fragmented without coordination and institutional recognition.

A dedicated section examines Israel's existing resources, major evidence gaps, regulatory and infrastructure barriers, high premises costs and the difficulties faced by small repair businesses seeking to formalise their activity. The final, practical section offers tools for residents, civic initiatives and municipalities: a neighbourhood repair-potential audit, a framework for converting a pilot into a municipal programme, and a realistic one-year action plan.

An accompanying policy appendix for Israel is being prepared as part of the manuscript. It considers the possible roles of municipalities, national authorities, civic organisations, educational institutions, repair professionals and small businesses in advancing repair, reuse and waste prevention. The recommendations are intended as a basis for professional discussion and further adaptation to Israel's institutional and municipal context.